

er forms,” says Shobu Yarlagadda, Co-founder and CEO of Arka Media Works, a production and media company in the Telugu content space, which has produced the *Baahubali* films. Movie-watching is not limited to the big screen now, and OTTs have made that possible. “Themes driven by emotions make for OTT viewing, while [something like] a biopic or a drama is more suitable for collective viewing.”

Devang Sampat, MD of Cinépolis India, a prominent player in the exhibition business with 449 screens, mentions the post-pandemic evolving consumer behaviour as a big tipping point. “India saw a steady number of annual moviegoers before that with consistent admits across regions. The disruption saw a 30% decline in admits in the first year followed by another 20% in the second,” he says. Since then, movie-watching has returned to pre-pandemic levels. “Now, there is an opportunity for exhibitors to re-engage the audience, through innovative offerings and tailored experiences.”

Even today, with more technology and data at one’s disposal, analytics models are very handy to determine, say, when and where to release a film or with how many prints or decide what kind of promotions need to be done.

“There is no end to what one can possibly do—like choosing your favourite stars or deciding how a movie should end,” says Mantha. It is a point that Yarlagadda agrees with and he speaks of how pre-testing of a concept will get even sharper. He says data must be used smartly to understand segmentation better and what the difficult part for data to grasp is the gut factor.

Not surprisingly, it all comes down to great content and a focus on screenplay. Pointing to the recent success of *Street* 2, a horror comedy,

PHOTO BY MANDAR DEODHAR



KIRAN MANI

CEO, VIACOM18
DIGITAL VENTURES

“India is in a prime digital phase... Entertainment in India remains an untapped value, presenting a significant opportunity”

Yarlagadda says that a strong script will always receive a good opening.

Coming to sports, living in the present is often at one’s peril. For instance, cricket brings in the eyeballs and consequently, revenue. But, Deloitte’s Mantha believes, it will continue to be an expensive medium. “There will always be interest and with women’s cricket, the attempt is clearly to increase the audience base. That said, we are also seeing the emergence of other sports like football slowly getting popular.”

All said and done, the focus is and will be on digital, similar to the situation we saw when the IPL rights were bought by Viacom18 for a whopping ₹23,578 crore. “India

is in a prime digital phase, and we are the largest entertainment market globally, with over a billion devices connected through mobile and television. To us, entertainment in India remains an untapped value, presenting a significant opportunity,” says Mani.

With technology and digital playing pivotal roles, how consumers open up their wallets to create a viable monetisation model will be key to watch. All in all, entertainment in India is scripting a new narrative and one can only hope for a happy ending. **BT**

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